

Elizabeth and Scarlet's Adventures

Ages 9-12 Middle Grade Printable Edition

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Chapter 1: The Race Through the Great Hall

Page 1

Elizabeth and Scarlet were ten-year-old princesses, which meant everyone expected them to walk slowly, speak politely, and never slide across the marble floor in roller skates. Unfortunately, the marble floor was perfect for roller skates. It shone like ice under the tall windows of the Royal Castle. Sunlight poured through stained glass and painted red, blue, and gold shapes across the Great Hall. Scarlet stood at....

Page 2

"Fine," Elizabeth said. "But no pushing. And no screaming. And no crashing into royal things." "You make it sound like I crash into royal things all the time." "Last week you crashed into a suit of armor and apologized to it." "It looked offended." They crouched at the starting line they had made from a strip of sunlight. "One," Elizabeth said. "Two," Scarlet said..

Page 3

"Three!" They flew. Their wheels hummed on the floor. Their capes snapped behind them. They passed the portraits of ancient kings and queens, who all looked as if they wished someone would invent a rule against children. Scarlet took the lead first, laughing so hard she nearly lost her balance. Elizabeth leaned forward, caught up, and glided beside her. The finish line was the doorway to the Pedestal Room, where Dad....

Page 4

For one tiny second, both girls believed it might stay upright. Then it fell. CRASH! The sound cracked through the castle like thunder. Blue glass burst across the floor in hundreds of tiny sparkling pieces. The shards glittered like crushed blue ice. Scarlet covered her mouth. Elizabeth stared at the empty pedestal. "Tell me that was not the vase," Scarlet whispered..

Page 5

"It was the vase." "Tell me it was not Dad's favorite vase." Elizabeth swallowed. "It was Dad's favorite vase." They stood perfectly still, listening for footsteps. None came. The castle seemed to be holding its breath with them. "We have to fix it," Scarlet said. "How? It is in a million pieces." "Then we fix a million pieces."

Page 6

They knelt on the floor, carefully gathering the glass into a silk scarf. Some pieces were big and curved. Others were tiny as sugar crystals. Elizabeth's hands shook. Scarlet's eyes kept darting toward the door. "We are in so much trouble," Scarlet said. "Not if we fix it first." "That is not how trouble works." They pushed the smallest glittering pieces under the shelf beside the pedestal, then carried the rest to....

Chapter 2: Max Makes a Deal

Page 7

The knock was neat, slow, and impossible to ignore. Elizabeth and Scarlet looked at each other. The silk scarf full of broken glass sat on Elizabeth's bed, glittering like a guilty secret. "Hide it," Scarlet mouthed. Elizabeth shoved it under a pillow just as the door opened. Max the Butler stepped in carrying a silver breakfast tray. He wore his white suit, polished black shoes, and a rainbow tie that should have....

Page 8

"At eight in the morning?" "A breakfast snack," Scarlet added. Max set the tray down. His eyes moved across the room. He saw the pillow. He saw the corner of blue glass peeking out. He saw the girls trying to look innocent, which made them look the opposite of innocent. "Princesses," he said, "is there something you would like to tell me?" "No," Scarlet said. "Maybe," Elizabeth said at the same time..

Page 9

Max lifted one eyebrow. Elizabeth pulled the scarf from under the pillow. The blue shards clinked together softly. Scarlet stared at her socks. "It was an accident," Elizabeth said. "We were skating and the floor was slippery and the pedestal was too close to the corner." "The pedestal has been in the same spot for two hundred years," Max said. "Then it has been too close to the corner for two hundred years,"....

Page 10

"Please wait," Scarlet begged. "Please, Max. We will fix it." "We will do anything," Elizabeth said. Max folded his gloved hands behind his back. "Anything is a dangerous word." "Anything reasonable," Elizabeth corrected. "Very well. I will keep your secret for now. But tonight, during the Queen's speech, you must behave perfectly. No running. No whispering. No skating. No making faces at visiting dukes. No....

Page 11

Elizabeth nudged Scarlet before she could answer. "We promise," Elizabeth said. Max leaned closer. "If you break this promise, I go straight to your father." The girls nodded. "And princesses?" "Yes, Max?".

Page 12

He glanced at the hidden shards. "Some secrets become heavier the longer you carry them." After he left, the room felt too quiet. "Do you think he will tell?" Scarlet asked. "Not if we behave." "Can you behave for an entire speech?" Elizabeth looked at the pancakes, the broken glass, and her sister's worried face. "For the vase," she said, "I can try."

Chapter 3: The Queen's Speech and the Fifty-Dollar Treats

Page 13

That evening, the castle lawn glittered with lanterns. Musicians played near the fountain. Guests arrived in shiny shoes and dresses that rustled like wrapping paper. The Queen's speech was the biggest event of the season, and everyone expected the princesses to sit like perfect statues. Scarlet and Elizabeth had never been good statues. They sat on velvet chairs near the front. Max stood along the wall with the....

Page 14

The Queen stepped onto the stage. She wore a blue dress that sparkled like the night sky. When she began speaking, everyone went silent. "Tonight," the Queen said, "we celebrate family, honesty, and the things we protect because they matter to us." Elizabeth stopped breathing. "Like our home," the Queen continued, "our traditions, and the treasures passed down through generations." Scarlet's fingers gripped the....

Page 15

Across the room, Max gave them a tiny look. Not mean. Not angry. Just a reminder. Behave. So they behaved. They did not run. They did not whisper. Scarlet did not make faces at the Duke of Plumford, even though he sneezed into a napkin shaped like a swan. Elizabeth did not complain when the speech seemed to last forever. When the final applause ended, Dad came over looking proud. "You two were very patient tonight,"

Page 16

Scarlet and Elizabeth exchanged a look. This was their chance. "Father," Elizabeth said in her most polite voice, "may we please have money for the ice cream truck?" "The speech made us very thirsty," Scarlet added. Dad laughed and pulled out a crisp fifty-dollar bill. "Stay close to the castle gates. And bring back change." "We will," Elizabeth said..

Page 17

They ran toward the truck, but not too fast because Max was still watching. The truck was painted bright purple, with a smiling penguin holding a cone on the side. The man inside had a beard so fluffy it looked as if a cloud had landed on his chin. Scarlet ordered the princess treat with bubble-gum eyes. Elizabeth ordered the flag one with red, white, and blue stripes. They sat on the grass while the syrup stained....

Page 18

"Behave forever?" "Fix what we broke." Scarlet took one last bite of bubble-gum eye and made a face. "That sounds harder." "It probably is." Neither of them knew yet that the broken vase was not only a problem. It was the first clue..

Chapter 4: Operation Ice Cream

Page 19

The problem with getting one amazing treat is that it makes you want another. By bedtime, Scarlet and Elizabeth were supposed to be asleep. Instead, they lay wide awake in their bunks, thinking about ice cream, the broken vase, and the way Max had looked at them as if he knew every thought in their heads. "I am still hungry," Scarlet whispered from the top bunk. "You ate two bubble-gum eyes." "That is not dinner."....

Page 20

"I know." "And we are not taking money from his pocket." "I know that too." Scarlet hung upside down from the top bunk, her hair swinging. "But remember the coin jar from the Royal Fair?" Elizabeth sat up. Last summer they had won a jar of gold-colored fair coins at a ring toss booth. The coins were not royal money, but the ice cream man accepted them because he liked the Royal Fair and because Scarlet had once....

Page 21

"Operation Ice Cream," Elizabeth whispered. "Operation Ice Cream," Scarlet agreed. They dressed in black hoodies and fuzzy socks. Shoes clicked. Fuzzy socks glided. Elizabeth tucked a small mirror into her pocket for peeking around corners. Scarlet carried the coin jar wrapped in a towel so it would not clink. The castle at night was a different place. Moonlight silvered the floors. Curtains moved like ghosts. Every....

Page 22

"I forgot how exciting bad ideas feel." "This is not a bad idea. It is a questionable mission." They made it outside. The ice cream truck still glowed near the gate, its freezer humming. Julio, the man with the cloud beard, leaned out the window. "Princesses," he said. "Secret snack mission?" "You saw nothing," Scarlet said, handing over the coins. They bought two sundaes and hurried back with chocolate on their....

Page 23

The next morning, Max entered with breakfast and stopped in the doorway. Scarlet had chocolate on her cheek. Elizabeth had a sprinkle stuck to her chin. Max looked at them. Then at the empty sundae cups hidden badly under the bed. "Princesses," he said, "we appear to have a pattern." "A small pattern," Scarlet said..

Page 24

"A sticky pattern," Max said. Because of the midnight heist, the girls had to clean Max's butler room for a week. They dusted shoes, folded white gloves, and organized rainbow ties by color. Scarlet held up a tie covered in tiny pineapples. "Why do you own this?" "A butler must be prepared for tropical emergencies," Max said. Elizabeth laughed for the first time in days. She did not know that pineapple tie would....

Chapter 5: The Sky Zone Stakeout

Page 25

After three days of cleaning Max's butler room, the sisters needed to jump somewhere that was not full of shoe polish. So Dad took them to Sky Zone. For the first twenty minutes, Elizabeth and Scarlet bounced, flipped into foam pits, and laughed until their sides hurt. Scarlet invented a move called the Royal Jellyfish, which was mostly falling with confidence. Elizabeth practiced a careful spin and landed it twice.....

Page 26

"Max," Elizabeth whispered. They bounced to the dodgeball court. A mustache ducked behind a pillar. They walked toward the water fountain. A polished black shoe slid under a bench. "He is spying on us," Scarlet said. "Badly." "Very badly." The girls made a plan. They walked toward a blue pillar and pretended not to notice the grown man in a trench coat hiding behind it. "Oh," Scarlet said loudly, "I wonder where Max...."

Page 27

"Yes," Elizabeth said. "When will our favorite butler pick us up? I hope he is not secretly watching from behind that very obvious pillar." Max stepped out, attempting dignity. The trench coat was too short. His rainbow tie hung sideways. Foam cubes clung to his hair. "I was ensuring your safety," he said. "You were spying," Scarlet said. "For safety." "With a fake mustache over your real mustache?" Elizabeth asked..

Page 28

Max touched his face. The fake mustache had slipped onto his chin. "A disguise must have layers," he said. The sisters crossed their arms exactly the way Max did when he was disappointed. "Since you caught us during Operation Ice Cream," Elizabeth said, "and since we caught you during Operation Sneaky Butler, we need a trade." "A reasonable trade," Max said quickly. "You buy us medium sodas on the way home," Scarlet....

Page 29

Max gasped. "The Ladybug Room? With the glitter drawer?" "Especially the glitter drawer." Max sighed. "Very well." On the ride home, Scarlet chose grape soda and Elizabeth chose orange cream. Max drove with the solemn expression of a man who had lost a battle. "Do not forget the beds," Scarlet said. "And the desks," Elizabeth said. "And the glitter drawer," Scarlet added..

Page 30

Max looked at them in the rearview mirror. His mustache twitched. "Royal Detectives," he muttered, "are very dangerous people." Elizabeth blinked. "What did you call us?" "Nothing," Max said. But Scarlet had heard it too. Royal Detectives. It sounded like a title waiting for them..

Chapter 6: Ms. Ironfist's Test

Page 31

The Royal Academy looked friendly from the outside. It had flower boxes, arched windows, and a bell tower that chimed politely every hour. Inside Room Four, nothing was polite. Ms. Ironfist ruled math class with a wooden ruler, a gray suit, and eyebrows that looked permanently disappointed. She believed fun was what happened after homework, and only if homework was perfect. "Monthly Mastery Test," she announced one....

Page 32

Elizabeth had studied. She studied because numbers made sense if she stared at them long enough. Scarlet had meant to study, but the week had included a broken vase, a secret heist, Sky Zone, and Max's shoe collection. The test began. The room filled with pencil scratches. Elizabeth's pencil moved steadily. Scarlet stared at the first problem. The numbers seemed to wiggle. When Ms. Ironfist returned the papers,....

Page 33

"Pack your books," Ms. Ironfist said. "You will attend Basics Math across the hall until further notice." Scarlet's face burned. Elizabeth wanted to protest, but Ms. Ironfist's ruler tapped the desk once, which meant no one should speak unless they wanted to become a cautionary example. Across the hall, Basics Math was not terrible. The teacher smiled. The problems were easier. But Scarlet hated being there because....

Page 34

"I do not care about the grade," she said into her pillow. "I care about us." Elizabeth sat beside her. "Then we get you back." For one month, their room became a study camp. Elizabeth made flashcards. Scarlet solved problems on a whiteboard. They practiced fractions while Max dusted the shelves, because he still owed them room cleaning. "Carry the one," Elizabeth said. "I am carrying it," Scarlet said. "It is....

Page 35

"Numbers are not actually heavy." "This one is." They laughed, then tried again. On the next test day, Scarlet's hands shook, but she knew the steps. She lined up the numbers. She checked her answers. She did not let panic boss her around. The next morning, the principal came into Basics Math with Scarlet's paper..

Page 36

One hundred percent. Scarlet ran back to Room Four. Elizabeth jumped out of her seat and hugged her before Ms. Ironfist could object. For once, even Ms. Ironfist did not look completely angry. "Acceptable improvement," she said. From Ms. Ironfist, that was basically a parade..

Chapter 7: The Sunflower Substitute

Page 37

The next week, Room Four smelled different. Usually it smelled like chalk, sharpened pencils, and fear. That morning it smelled like lavender and oranges. Ms. Ironfist's desk was empty. A woman swept into the room wearing a sunflower dress so bright it seemed to bring its own weather. She had brown hair, blue eyes, and a basket full of juice boxes. "Good morning! I am Mrs. Rosie. Ms. Ironfist is home sick, so I will....

Page 38

A whisper moved through the class. Home sick? Ms. Ironfist seemed like someone who would scare germs into leaving. Mrs. Rosie passed out clementines and announced that math would happen outside in the garden. Scarlet looked at Elizabeth. Elizabeth looked at Scarlet. Math outside sounded illegal..

Page 39

In the garden, Mrs. Rosie taught them how to measure shadows to estimate the height of sunflowers. Scarlet made a mistake and braced for a ruler tap, but Mrs. Rosie only knelt beside her. "Try again from this line," she said. "Mistakes are just clues wearing disguises." Scarlet liked that. Elizabeth did too. At lunch, Scarlet noticed a photograph slipping out of Mrs. Rosie's bag. It showed Mrs. Rosie with her arm....

Page 40

Scarlet nearly dropped her juice box. "You know Ms. Ironfist?" she asked. Mrs. Rosie smiled. "We were roommates in college." "But she is..." Scarlet searched for a polite word. "Terrifying," Elizabeth supplied..

Page 41

Mrs. Rosie laughed. "She takes teaching seriously. Very seriously. But when she is not holding a ruler, she tells excellent jokes." The girls tried to imagine Ms. Ironfist telling a joke. Their brains refused. For the rest of the week, Mrs. Rosie made the classroom feel like a place where questions were allowed. The students still worked hard, but they breathed while doing it. On Friday, she announced a surprise.....

Page 42

Elizabeth sat up straighter. Scarlet felt the word secrets buzz in the air. Mrs. Rosie glanced at them for just one second too long. Maybe it was nothing. Or maybe Mrs. Rosie knew the castle was not done with them yet..

Chapter 8: The Ladybug Room

Page 43

The new room was a reward for many things: surviving math, helping each other, and perhaps keeping Dad distracted from the empty pedestal long enough for the girls to find a solution. Mom opened a carved door in a part of the castle the girls had never used. "Surprise," she said. Elizabeth and Scarlet stepped inside and forgot how to talk. The walls were painted like a meadow. Green grass curled around the corners.....

Page 44

Dad smiled. "Press the button." "What button?" Elizabeth noticed a corner of the rug sticking up. Under it was a gold button shaped like a star. Scarlet pressed it. WHOOSH! Water rushed down the slide. "It goes to the pool," Dad said..

Page 45

Scarlet screamed with joy. Elizabeth tried not to scream because she was the slightly older sister, but joy won. That night, after their parents left, the room glowed. The rainbow stars shone in neon colors. The ladybugs lit up like tiny nightlights. "Best room ever," Scarlet whispered from the top bunk. Elizabeth agreed from the bottom bunk. Then the walkie-talkie on Elizabeth's desk crackled. The girls froze..

Page 46

They had not turned it on. Static hissed. A voice whispered through the speaker. "The map is behind the bunk... find the star..." Scarlet leaned over the rail. "Did your walkie-talkie just talk by itself?" "Yes." "Do walkie-talkies do that?"

Page 47

"No." The speaker crackled again. "Find the star." Elizabeth climbed out of bed too quickly. Her foot slipped on the rug, hit the gold button, and the slide roared to life. She stumbled backward and went down the slide in her pajamas. "Elizabeth!" Scarlet yelled. Scarlet jumped after her. They shot through the tunnel and splashed into the heated pool below. When they climbed out, dripping and breathless, the....

Page 48

They ran back to the room and pulled the bunk bed away from the wall. Behind it, carved into the stone, was a tiny star. Scarlet touched it. Something clicked. A seam appeared in the wall. Elizabeth smiled despite her wet hair. "I think," she said, "our room has a secret."

Chapter 9: The Field Trip Note

Page 49

The Whispering Woods did not whisper like people. It whispered like leaves rubbing together, water moving under stones, and birds hiding secrets in their songs. Mrs. Rosie led the class along a path lined with silver ferns. Everyone carried notebooks. Most students wrote down facts about moss. Scarlet and Elizabeth carried notebooks too, but Scarlet also carried a compass they had found behind the carved star in....

Page 50

The needle stopped, pointing away from the path toward an enormous hollow oak tree. Mrs. Rosie was explaining the difference between harmless mushrooms and mushrooms that screamed when stepped on. The class was distracted. The girls slipped closer to the tree. Inside the hollow trunk, something gleamed. Elizabeth reached in and pulled out a silver envelope. It was dusty on the outside, but the seal was fresh purple....

Page 51

Elizabeth broke the seal. Inside was one sentence written in shiny purple ink. I see you have found the compass. Meet me at the Crystal Cave. A chill moved through Scarlet. "Someone knows." "About the compass?".

Page 52

"About us." A twig snapped behind them. They spun around. Mrs. Rosie stood on the path holding her clipboard. For a second, Elizabeth thought they were caught. But Mrs. Rosie only smiled. "The Messenger Tree is very old," she said. "People used to leave important notes there." "This note is not old," Elizabeth said before she could stop herself..

Page 53

Mrs. Rosie's smile did not change. "Then it must be very important." She turned back to the class. Scarlet stared after her. "Does she know?" "I do not know." "Do we trust her?" Elizabeth folded the note and tucked it into her notebook..

Page 54

"Not yet," she said. The wind moved through the trees, and for one moment the woods really did seem to whisper. Crystal Cave. Crystal Cave. Crystal Cave..

Chapter 10: Picnic at the Crystal Cave

Page 55

The next day, Mom announced a family picnic near the Whispering Woods. Scarlet nearly dropped her spoon into her cereal. "The woods?" she asked. "The weather is perfect," Mom said. "And your father insists he knows the best place for strawberry tarts." Dad looked proud. "I do. It is called anywhere I bring strawberry tarts."

Page 56

The picnic spot was a sunny clearing near the edge of the woods. Guards unloaded baskets. Max spread a blanket with perfect corners. Mom arranged sandwiches. Dad argued gently with a jar of jam. Elizabeth touched the blue compass in her pocket. "We are going to pick flowers," Scarlet announced. Max looked at them for one extra second. "Flowers." "Yes," Elizabeth said. "Outdoor flowers. From outside." "How...."

Page 57

The girls hurried away before he could ask more questions. Once hidden by trees, Scarlet pulled out the compass. The needle trembled, then pointed toward a curtain of vines hanging over a cliffside. Behind the vines was a cave entrance. Inside, purple crystals grew from the walls. They glowed with the same color as the ink on the note. The air smelled cold and sweet, like rain on stone. At the center of the cave....

Page 58

Scarlet whispered, "That is either thoughtful or terrifying." Beside the sodas sat a wooden box. Scritch. Scratch. The girls froze. A mechanical owl hopped out from behind a crystal. It had brass wings, glass eyes, and feet that clicked on stone. It looked at them, hooted once, and tapped the box..

Page 59

"Is it telling us to open it?" Elizabeth asked. "Either that or it wants a sandwich." Elizabeth opened the box. Inside lay a blue shard of glass. Not just any glass. Vase glass. Sparkly, ice-blue, and shaped like a missing piece from their secret bundle. Scarlet's face went pale. "How did that get here?"

Page 60

The owl blinked its light-bulb eyes. From outside, Mom called, "Girls! Lunch!" Elizabeth grabbed the shard. Scarlet grabbed the sodas because fear was no reason to waste grape soda. They ran back to the picnic with the biggest question yet. Who had found a piece of the broken vase before they did?.

Chapter 11: The Clue in the Glass

Page 61

Back at the picnic, Elizabeth could barely taste her sandwich. Scarlet ignored a strawberry tart, which proved the situation was serious. The blue shard lay hidden under Elizabeth's napkin. In the sunlight, it flashed. "Look," Scarlet whispered. Inside the glass, tiny frosted letters appeared. Elizabeth tilted it, and the words sharpened. THE ROYAL CLOCKTOWER. Under the words was a drawing of a gear and a wrench..

Page 62

"It is not just a shard," Elizabeth said. "It is a clue." "A clue left by someone who knows we broke the vase." "And someone who knows about the cave." "And someone who knows our soda flavors," Scarlet added. That night, after the castle quieted, the sisters crept toward the Royal Clocktower. The tower rose above the castle like a giant stone finger pointing at the moon. Its gears clicked and clacked behind the....

Page 63

Scarlet carried the blue shard. Elizabeth carried the compass. They climbed the spiral stairs, higher and higher, until their legs ached. At the top, the clock room glowed gold. Huge gears turned slowly. Bells hung above them like sleeping giants. A hooded figure stood beside the clock face. Scarlet grabbed Elizabeth's hand. The figure turned. "You are late," it said..

Page 64

Elizabeth knew that voice. "Max?" The hood came down. Max the Butler stood there, not in his white suit but in an inventor's apron covered with pockets. Goggles sat on his forehead. A remote control rested in his gloved hand. "You made the owl," Scarlet said. "Yes." "You left the notes," Elizabeth said..

Page 65

"Also yes." "You knew about the vase." Max's face softened. "I knew." Scarlet stepped forward. "Why did you not tell?" Max looked at the gears turning behind him. "Because my job is not only serving breakfast. I am the Castle Keeper. I watch over its secrets. And sometimes I test whether the next generation is ready to protect them..".

Page 66

"By scaring us?" Scarlet asked. "By giving you the chance to become brave." Elizabeth held up the shard. "Can the vase be fixed?" Max reached into his apron and pulled out a small bottle glowing with warm golden light. "With this," he said. "But fixing the vase is only half the task. The other half is telling the truth." The bells above them began to hum, as if the tower itself agreed..

Chapter 12: Golden Glue

Page 67

The golden glue smelled like honey, sunshine, and the warm part of toast. That was Scarlet's description. Elizabeth thought it smelled like second chances. They locked themselves in the Ladybug Room with the bundle of blue shards spread across black velvet. Before touching the glue, Elizabeth held up her camera. "We need a before picture," she said. "Why would we want proof of how bad it was?" Scarlet asked..

Page 68

"Because Mom should see we did not pretend it never happened." Flash. The broken glass sparkled under the camera light. Then they began. It took hours. The pieces were not simple. Some curved. Some had painted petals. Some were so small Scarlet had to hold them with tweezers. Elizabeth touched the golden glue to one edge, and the glass seemed to pull toward its missing partner. "It wants to be whole," Scarlet....

Page 69

Gold lines formed wherever cracks had been. Not ugly lines. Beautiful ones. They looked like lightning, rivers, and secret paths on a treasure map. Max knocked once and entered with sandwiches. "How goes the repair?" "Slow," Elizabeth said. "Sticky," Scarlet said. "Good," Max said. "Most important repairs are both."

Page 70

When they finally finished, the vase stood on Elizabeth's desk. It was still shimmer blue, but now gold veins ran through it. The roses looked brighter. The broken places had become part of the design. Scarlet touched the table, not the vase. "It is prettier now." Elizabeth took the after picture. Then came the hard part. They found Mom in the Royal Library. Dad was there too, reading a book upside down because he....

Page 71

Then they told everything. The race. The crash. The hiding. Max's deal. The clues. The Clocktower. The golden glue. Mom looked at the before picture. Then the after picture. Then the vase. For a moment, she said nothing. Scarlet's eyes filled with tears. Mom opened her arms. "That is okay," she said. "I forgive you. I am just glad you told the truth."

Page 72

The girls ran into her hug. Dad woke up, looked at the vase, and blinked. "Why does my vase look more magical?" Elizabeth laughed through her tears. "Long story," she said. Mom smiled. "A very good one."

Chapter 13: Royal Detectives

Page 73

The next morning, Max placed a small wooden sign on the Ladybug Room door. ROYAL DETECTIVE HEADQUARTERS. Underneath, in smaller letters, he had added: NO BUTLERS WITHOUT KNOCKING. "You wrote that yourself," Scarlet said. "A wise butler obeys future rules before they become official," Max said..

Page 74

Inside the room, the sisters arranged their tools: walkie-talkies, the blue compass, the camera, the small mirror from Operation Ice Cream, and a notebook labeled Important Clues and Also Snacks. Elizabeth liked lists. Scarlet liked snacks. The notebook made both of them happy. For one whole day, nothing mysterious happened. This was unacceptable. "Maybe mysteries take weekends off," Scarlet said. Elizabeth studied....

Page 75

"Do you think the vase was always a map?" she asked. Scarlet leaned closer. "I think everything in this castle is secretly a map. Even the soup spoons." That night, the blue compass began to glow on Elizabeth's desk. Not a big glow. A pulse. Thump. Thump..

Page 76

Thump. The sisters sat up in bed. "That is new," Scarlet said. The compass needle spun, stopped, and pointed toward the window. Beyond the castle walls lay the Whispering Woods. Beyond the woods lay the waterfall near Crystal Cave. Elizabeth opened the notebook. "Case number two," she said. "The pulsing compass..".

Page 77

"Case number two should have a scarier name." "The Mysterious Pulsing Compass?" "Better." They did not go that night. They had learned at least one lesson about sneaking around half-asleep. But in the morning, with backpacks packed and Max pretending not to notice the extra marshmallows, the Royal Detectives left for the woods. The compass pulsed faster the closer they came to the waterfall. Thump-thump..

Page 78

Thump-thump. The sound was not only in the compass now. It came from behind the falling water, deep inside the cave. Scarlet whispered, "Please tell me caves normally have heartbeats." Elizabeth stared at the purple mist curling around the rocks. "I do not think so." Together, they stepped through the waterfall..

Chapter 14: The Egg in the Mist

Page 79

Behind the waterfall, the world turned silver and purple. Mist curled around Elizabeth's ankles. Drops of water clung to Scarlet's eyelashes. The cave did not feel cold like before. It felt warm, as if something inside it had been breathing. Thump-thump. Thump-thump. They followed the sound past the stone table, past the place where the mechanical owl had first appeared, and into a chamber they had not noticed....

Page 80

In the nest was an egg. It was enormous, almost the size of a beach ball. Its shell shimmered emerald green and gold. Warm light pulsed beneath the surface. "Is it a bird?" Scarlet whispered. "Maybe." "A giant bird?" "Maybe." "A dinosaur?"

Page 81

Elizabeth looked at the glowing shell. "I really hope not." Scarlet reached out one finger. "Can I touch it?" "Carefully." The egg was warm. The moment Scarlet touched it, the thumping sound changed. Thump-thump-thump. Elizabeth opened the notebook with shaking hands..

Page 82

"Observation one," she whispered. "Large glowing egg found in Crystal Cave. Possible bird, dinosaur, or unknown magical creature." "Observation two," Scarlet said. "It likes me." "We do not know that." The egg pulsed again. "It likes me." They stayed for hours, guessing what might be inside. A phoenix. A mountain swan. A glitter turtle. Scarlet suggested a royal chicken the size of a sofa. Elizabeth wrote it down....

Page 83

When they finally left, Scarlet kept looking back. "We cannot tell everyone," she said. "No." "But we cannot leave it alone forever." "No." "So what do we do?" Elizabeth tucked the compass into her pocket. It was still pulsing, softer now..

Page 84

"We come back tomorrow." From inside the cave, something tapped gently against the shell. Tap. Tap. Tap. The sisters ran all the way home..

Chapter 15: Cinder Hatches

Page 85

The next morning, Elizabeth and Scarlet skipped their pancakes. Not because they were guilty this time. Because they were excited. They packed milk, marshmallows, a blanket, the camera, the notebook, and a sandwich for Max because he looked suspiciously as if he wanted to ask where they were going. "For me?" Max said, accepting the sandwich. "No questions sandwich," Scarlet said. "Ah," Max said. "My favorite kind."

Page 86

At the cave, the egg rocked in its nest. Crack. Gold light slipped through the shell. Crack-crack. Scarlet grabbed Elizabeth's arm. "It is happening." The top of the egg popped off and rolled into the moss. A small creature tumbled out, blinking at the world..

Page 87

It had four tiny legs, velvet wings, shimmering scales, and violet eyes. A soft ridge of golden spikes ran from its head to its tail. It sneezed, and glittery smoke puffed from its nose. Elizabeth's mouth fell open. "Dragon," she whispered. "Baby dragon," Scarlet whispered back, because this felt important. The dragon looked at them. Then it chirped. It was the least terrifying sound in the world..

Page 88

Scarlet held out her hand. The dragon waddled forward, sniffed her fingers, and pressed its warm head into her palm. "He likes me," Scarlet said. "This time," Elizabeth said, "I agree." They spent the afternoon learning dragon facts. He liked silver moss. He did not like loud camera flashes. He could flap his wings but not fly. His smoke smelled like toasted marshmallows. "We cannot bring him to the castle,"....

Page 89

Scarlet looked horrified. "I know. A castle has curtains. And wooden furniture. And Dad's eyebrows." "Dad's eyebrows?" "They would catch fire first. They are very expressive." The dragon sneezed again. Glitter smoke curled into the air. "He needs a name," Elizabeth said. They tried names all afternoon. Glimmer. Jax. Button. Sir Smoke-a-Lot. The dragon ignored all of them..

Page 90

Then Scarlet picked up a blackened bit of eggshell from where his first puff of smoke had warmed it. "Cinder," she said. The dragon perked up. "Cinder," Elizabeth repeated. The baby dragon chirped, flapped both wings, and fell over backward. Cinder had chosen his name..

Chapter 16: The Marshmallow Feast

Page 91

Cinder's first problem was hunger. His stomach growled so loudly that small crystals trembled on the cave wall. "Do dragons eat sandwiches?" Scarlet asked. Elizabeth checked the notebook. "We have no evidence." Cinder sniffed the sandwich and sneezed glitter smoke onto it. "Evidence suggests no," Elizabeth said..

Page 92

Scarlet opened the bag of marshmallows. Cinder's violet eyes widened. He waddled over so fast he tripped on his own tail. "Marshmallows," Scarlet said. "Evidence suggests yes." They poured milk into a small camping pot and added marshmallows. Elizabeth reached for a match, but Cinder leaned forward and breathed a tiny stream of golden fire. The milk warmed instantly. The marshmallows puffed and softened. "He made....

Page 93

Cinder slurped the warm milk and gooey marshmallows with such happiness that both girls started laughing. "This is his food," Elizabeth said. "Warm milk and boiled marshmallows." "Every day," Scarlet said. "We visit every day." That sounded simple until they tried it. Visiting a secret dragon every day required planning. They had to sneak milk from the kitchen without alarming the cook. They had to carry....

Page 94

"That is a large bag," he said. "School project," Elizabeth said. "About marshmallows?" "Science," Scarlet said. Max looked at the bag. Then at the girls. Then at the window facing the woods. "Science can be sticky," he said. "Be careful."

Page 95

He let them pass. Inside the cave, Cinder was growing stronger. His wings stretched wider. His golden fire warmed the walls. When he curled up in the silver moss after eating, he looked peaceful and safe. Scarlet sat beside him. "We will protect you." Elizabeth nodded. "Royal Detective promise." Cinder opened one violet eye and hummed..

Page 96

The cave wall shimmered. For one second, the girls saw an image in the stone: themselves walking through the woods earlier that day. Then it vanished. Elizabeth grabbed the notebook. "New evidence," she whispered. Cinder had another secret..

Chapter 17: Echo-Vision

Page 97

They called it Echo-Vision because Scarlet said "magic cave movie eyes" was too long to write in the notebook. Cinder could hum and make the cave wall show things that had already happened. At first, it was funny. He showed Scarlet tripping over a root four times. He showed Elizabeth making her serious thinking face while holding a marshmallow bag upside down. "I do not make that face," Elizabeth said. The wall....

Page 98

But Echo-Vision was not only funny. It was useful. Cinder showed them deer walking near the cave at dawn. He showed the mechanical owl hopping across a ledge weeks earlier. He showed Max in the Clocktower, testing the remote before the girls ever found the first note. Then the picture changed. The cave wall darkened. A tall figure moved through the woods near the waterfall. The figure wore a cloak and carried....

Page 99

Cinder hummed lower. The image sharpened. Purple mist curled around the stranger's boots. Elizabeth checked the angle of the sun in the image. "This morning." "Someone was here this morning?" Cinder's wings pressed tight to his sides. He was scared. The next day, the girls returned with extra supplies: blankets, more milk, marshmallows, a small brush for Cinder's scales, and three detective shovels because Scarlet....

Page 100

"We need to hide the entrance," Elizabeth said. Cinder seemed to understand. He waddled to the cave mouth and breathed silver mist. It spread over the opening, thick and shining. "Not fire," Scarlet said. "Mist." The mist hardened when it touched stone. Elizabeth and Scarlet piled rocks and moss against it. Cinder warmed the edges with golden fire until the new wall blended into the cliff. From outside, it looked....

Page 101

From inside, it had one secret place to push. "Invisible wall," Scarlet said proudly. "Disguised wall," Elizabeth corrected. "Invisible sounds cooler." Cinder chirped. "Cinder votes invisible."

Page 102

They were still admiring it when a heavy knock struck the other side. Thump. Thump. Thump. Someone had found the wall..

Chapter 18: The Face Beyond Stone

Page 103

No one breathed. Outside the disguised wall, the knocking came again. Thump. Thump. Scarlet pulled Cinder into the shadows. Elizabeth clicked off her flashlight. The cave glowed only with Cinder's violet eyes. A muffled voice came through the stone. "Royal Detectives?".

Page 104

Scarlet's eyes widened. "Max?" she whispered. Elizabeth held up a hand. It could be a trick. Detectives did not open secret dragon walls just because someone sounded like their butler. Cinder stepped forward and hummed. Echo-Vision shimmered across the inside of the wall. But instead of showing the past, it showed the shape of the person outside, glowing blue like an X-ray. It was Max. He wore inventor goggles and....

Page 105

"I know you are in there," Max called softly. "And before anyone breathes fire at me, I am on your side." Cinder growled. "He said before," Scarlet warned. Cinder took a breath. "Cinder, no!" Elizabeth said. A stream of golden fire shot toward the base of the wall. The stones glowed red. Outside, Max yelped. "Easy, little fellow! Friendly butler! Friendly butler!".

Page 106

Scarlet grabbed a handful of marshmallows. "Cinder, snack!" Cinder turned so fast he almost fell over. He accepted the marshmallows with dignity, as if he had not just attempted to toast Max through a mountain. Elizabeth pushed the secret stone. Part of the wall opened. Max stepped inside, brushing dust from his sleeves. "A dragon," he said, staring at Cinder. "A baby dragon," Scarlet said. "Named Cinder," Elizabeth....

Page 107

Max removed his goggles. "The castle sensors picked up a dragon heartbeat. I hoped they were wrong. Sensors are rarely wrong, which is inconvenient." "Are you going to tell?" Scarlet asked. Max looked at Cinder, who had marshmallow fluff on his nose. "No. The castle is full of people who would not understand. The King has scouts. The kingdom has collectors. A dragon this young is safest here." Elizabeth felt her....

Page 108

Max nodded. "Milk deliveries. Marshmallow cover stories. Sensor blockers. I can be useful." Cinder sniffed Max's rainbow tie. "He likes you," Scarlet said. Cinder sneezed glitter smoke onto Max's shoes. Max looked down. "A high honor, I assume." "Very high," Elizabeth said. The secret team had grown..

Chapter 19: The Stealth Flight

Page 109

Cinder grew faster than anyone expected. One week after Max joined the secret, Cinder's wings no longer looked like crumpled velvet. They stretched wide and strong, catching the cave air. He flapped them constantly, knocking over milk pots, stirring silver moss, and once blowing Scarlet's notebook into the waterfall. "He needs to fly," Scarlet said. "He needs to not be seen flying," Elizabeth said. Max arrived with....

Page 110

"Only unusually large squirrels." The girls strapped on the bracelets. Max adjusted the dials. Cinder watched with interest, then tried to eat one. "Not food," Elizabeth said. Cinder huffed. They waited until late afternoon, when the waterfall mist was thickest. Cinder stood at the cave entrance, trembling with excitement. "Low over the trees," Elizabeth said. "No roaring. No golden fire. No dramatic loops." Cinder....

Page 111

"That sounded like agreement," Scarlet said. "It sounded like a dragon saying he will consider it." Cinder breathed golden fog. It mixed with the waterfall spray until the whole clearing shimmered. Then he leaped. For one terrifying second, he dropped. Then his wings caught the air. He flew..

Page 112

Scarlet forgot to be quiet. "He is doing it!" Cinder skimmed above the ferns, wobbly but brave. Elizabeth ran below him, watching her bracelet. Scarlet laughed as Cinder sneezed glitter smoke and startled three birds out of a tree. Then Scarlet's bracelet buzzed. BUZZ-BUZZ. Elizabeth's buzzed too. Someone was coming. "Down!" Elizabeth hissed..

Page 113

Scarlet gave their secret birdcall, which sounded less like a bird and more like a hiccuping teapot, but Cinder understood. He dove into a patch of bushes just as a royal scout stepped into the clearing. The scout frowned at the golden mist. "Strange weather," he muttered. Cinder's tail stuck out from the bush. Scarlet stepped on it gently. Cinder pulled it in. The scout moved on..

Page 114

When the bracelets stopped buzzing, the girls collapsed with relief. Cinder crawled from the bush, leaves stuck to his horns. "First flight," Elizabeth said, writing with a shaking hand, "successful." "First hiding," Scarlet added, "needs practice." Above them, far beyond the trees, a bird circled once and flew toward the castle. Only it did not move like a bird. It moved like a machine..

Chapter 20: The Royal Hawaiian Jet

Page 115

The next mystery arrived in the form of a family vacation. "Hawaii," Mom announced at breakfast. Scarlet dropped her spoon. Elizabeth nearly spilled orange juice. Dad spread a map across the table. "Sun, beaches, volcanoes, sea caves, and absolutely no detective emergencies." Max coughed into a napkin..

Page 116

Elizabeth looked at Scarlet. Scarlet looked at Elizabeth. Cinder. They could not leave him alone in the cave for a whole vacation. They also could not walk into the airport with a dragon on a leash. Max solved the problem with a trunk. It looked like a normal royal luggage trunk, except it had hidden air vents, a warming pad, a milk compartment, and a sign inside that read DO NOT EAT THE HINGES..

Page 117

"For Cinder," Max explained. "He tried to eat the prototype." The flight was chaos disguised as elegance. Cinder loved clouds. Cinder hated seat belts. Cinder sneezed glitter smoke whenever the plane dipped. Scarlet fed him marshmallows through a secret flap. Elizabeth kept notes. Dad leaned back from the front of the jet. "Why does the luggage smell like toasted sugar?" "Travel snacks," Max said calmly. When they....

Page 118

Cinder stayed hidden in the trunk, grumpy but safe. The girls promised him a nighttime visit. On the beach, Scarlet and Elizabeth met a girl their age with sun-browned skin, sea-glass beads, and a surfboard under one arm. "You are staring at the cliffs," the girl said. "We like cliffs," Scarlet said. "And caves," Elizabeth added..

Page 119

The girl studied them. "Then you should know those cliffs are not normal. People call them the Whispering Tides." "Do they actually whisper?" Scarlet asked. "Only when they want something," the girl said. "What is your name?" Elizabeth asked. "Leilani..".

Page 120

A mechanical bird passed high overhead, glinting in the sun. Leilani looked up sharply. "That is new," she said. Elizabeth's Vibe-Link buzzed once. Vacation had lasted eleven minutes before becoming a case..

Chapter 21: Leilani and the Whispering Tides

Page 121

Leilani knew the island the way Elizabeth knew the castle: not just the obvious paths, but the hidden ones. She showed them tide pools full of tiny silver fish, black lava rocks warm from the sun, and flowers that smelled sweetest right before rain. "The Whispering Tides are over there," Leilani said, pointing to cliffs at the edge of the beach. "At low tide, a cave opens. My grandmother says it used to belong to...."

Page 122

Leilani shrugged. "Depends who tells the story. Birds, spirits, dragons, old machines. Sometimes all four." Elizabeth tried not to react to dragons. That night, they introduced Leilani to Cinder. It was not the plan. The plan was to keep Cinder hidden in the trunk, feed him warm milk, and ask Leilani normal questions about caves. Unfortunately, Cinder sneezed the trunk open. Leilani stared at him..

Page 123

Cinder stared back. Scarlet said, "This is our travel snack." Elizabeth closed her eyes. "No, it is not." Leilani stepped closer slowly. "He is beautiful.."

Page 124

Cinder sniffed her sea-glass necklace and chirped. "His name is Cinder," Scarlet said. "He trusts you," Elizabeth added. "That usually takes at least three marshmallows." Leilani sat on the floor. "My grandmother told me stories about fire friends who came from mountain eggs. I thought they were just stories.."

Page 125

"We did too," Elizabeth said. The next morning, at low tide, Leilani led them to the cave. Cinder flew under a cover of golden fog while the girls watched their Vibe-Links. Max followed carrying a beach umbrella, three towels, and a bag labeled DEFINITELY NOT DRAGON FOOD. Inside the Whispering Tides cave, the walls were black lava glass. When waves rushed through hidden tunnels, the cave hummed. Cinder hummed back.....

Page 126

They saw a picture from long ago: dragons flying over the island, wearing bands of blue light around their legs. Below them, people waved from canoes. Then the image shifted. A metal bird, like the one from the sky, landed on the cliff. Someone was still following dragon clues..

Chapter 22: The Lava Glass Map

Page 127

The lava glass wall held more than pictures. When Cinder's violet eyes glowed, golden lines appeared inside the black stone. They formed a map of the island: beaches, cliffs, jungle paths, and a bright mark at the volcano. Leilani touched the glowing mark. "That is Pu'u Ahi. Fire Hill. Tourists are not allowed near the old crater." "Good thing we are not tourists," Scarlet said. "We are absolutely tourists,"

Page 128

Max cleared his throat. "We are also not going to an unsafe crater without planning." The Vibe-Links buzzed. Everyone froze. Outside the cave, voices echoed. "The signal came from here," a man said..

Page 129

Another voice answered, "Find the source. The collector pays extra for living specimens." Cinder's wings flared. Leilani grabbed his neck gently. "Quiet, fire friend." Elizabeth's stomach turned cold. Collectors. Max had warned them about people who would not understand dragons. These people understood enough to be dangerous..

Page 130

The group slipped deeper into the cave. Waves rushed behind them, covering their footsteps. Scarlet held the compass. It spun, then pointed toward a narrow crack in the lava wall. "There," she whispered. They squeezed through one at a time. Max got stuck because of the beach umbrella. "Let go of the umbrella," Scarlet hissed. "A prepared butler--".

Page 131

"Max." He let go. On the other side, they found a chamber open to the sky. In the center stood a stone bowl filled with blue sand. Cinder stepped toward it, humming. The sand rose into the air and formed a shape: a saddle, but not for riding like a horse. It looked like a harness of light, something that could help a young dragon carry messages without being seen. Leilani smiled. "Sky guardian gear.".

Page 132

Elizabeth wrote quickly. "Dragon history confirmed. Island connected to Cinder's kind. Collectors nearby. Max lost umbrella." "That last note is unnecessary," Max said. A shadow crossed the open sky. The metal bird circled above them. This time, it had seen them..

Chapter 23: The Collector's Net

Page 133

The metal bird dropped a net. It unfolded in the air, silver and sparkling, falling straight toward Cinder. "Move!" Elizabeth shouted. Cinder jumped, but his wing caught on a rock. Scarlet threw herself forward and pulled him free. The net hit the ground where he had been, hissing as it tightened around empty stone. Leilani grabbed a shell from her pocket and blew into it. The sound was low and strong. Waves surged....

Page 134

"This way!" she yelled. They ran through the tide tunnels. Max carried Cinder for three steps, then Cinder objected by flapping in his face. Scarlet grabbed the marshmallow bag. Elizabeth followed the compass. Behind them, the collectors entered the cave. "Careful," one said. "The creature is valuable."

Page 135

Scarlet's face turned red. "He is not a creature. He is Cinder." "Argue later," Elizabeth said. They burst onto a hidden beach surrounded by cliffs. The only way out was up a narrow trail. Cinder was shaking. He had been brave in the woods, brave in the cave, brave in the sky, but the net had scared him badly. Elizabeth knelt beside him. "Listen to me. You do not have to be big to be brave. You just have to take the....

Page 136

Cinder pressed his head against her shoulder. The collectors appeared at the tunnel entrance. Max stepped in front of the girls. He looked ridiculous in a sandy suit and inventor goggles, but his voice was pure Castle Keeper. "You will not come closer." The collector laughed. "And who are you?"

Page 137

Max reached into his pocket and clicked a device. Every Vibe-Link buzzed at once. The sound bounced off the cliffs, multiplied by Echo-Vision and cave acoustics until it became a roar. Cinder lifted his head. His violet eyes glowed..

Page 138

The cliff behind the collectors lit with images: dragons flying free, children laughing with them, nets breaking, skies opening. The collectors stumbled back. "What is this?" one shouted. "A warning," Scarlet said. Cinder breathed golden fog. It rolled across the beach, thick and bright. When it cleared, the girls, Max, Leilani, and Cinder were gone, climbing the hidden trail toward Fire Hill..

Chapter 24: Fire Hill

Page 139

Fire Hill was not erupting, which everyone agreed was a good start. Steam curled from cracks in the black ground. Red flowers grew in impossible places. The air smelled like minerals and rain. Leilani led them along safe stones her grandmother had taught her, while Max checked every step with a device that beeped nervously. At the crater rim, the compass and the lava glass map both glowed. Cinder stepped forward..

Page 140

The ground answered with a hum. A ring of blue light rose from the stone, forming a circle around him. For a moment, Elizabeth was afraid it was a trap. Then the light softened, wrapping around Cinder like a gentle ribbon. Echo-Vision filled the steam. They saw Cinder's egg in the silver moss. They saw old dragons leaving the island, crossing the sea, hiding eggs in safe places. They saw Castle Keepers and island....

Page 141

The collector's metal bird buzzed overhead. Not now, Elizabeth thought. Not during this. The bird dove. Cinder looked up. He was still small. Still young. Still marshmallow-loving and easily startled..

Page 142

But he was not helpless. He spread his wings and released golden fire--not at the bird, but around it. The fire became a glowing ring. The metal bird spun, confused, then dropped harmlessly into a patch of soft ash. Max ran to it and pulled out a blinking crystal. "Tracker." "Can you stop it?" Elizabeth asked..

Page 143

Max smiled. "I can do better. I can send it home with a message." Leilani wrote the message on a scrap of paper. DRAGONS ARE NOT YOURS. Scarlet added: ALSO, YOUR NET IS RUDE..

Page 144

Max attached it to the metal bird, reprogrammed the tracker, and sent it wobbling away from the island. Cinder stood in the blue ring, glowing softly. The island had recognized him. And, somehow, it had recognized the girls too..

Chapter 25: The Sky Guardian Promise

Page 145

The vacation did not become normal after Fire Hill. It became better. Leilani's grandmother, Tutu Hana, invited them to her porch. She had silver hair, kind eyes, and the calm expression of someone who had been expecting a dragon for years. "So," she said, pouring guava juice, "the fire friend has returned."

Page 146

Cinder sat under the table eating warm milk-soaked marshmallows from a bowl. He wore the blue light harness from the cave, which shimmered whenever he moved. Tutu Hana told them the old story. Long ago, dragons carried messages between islands and kingdoms. They did not belong to anyone. They chose friends. They protected places where earth, sea, and sky met. "Collectors always come," Tutu Hana said. "They see magic...."

Page 147

Before they left Hawaii, Leilani gave the girls her sea-glass necklace. "For Cinder," she said. "If you ever need the island, hold it near water. The tides remember." Scarlet hugged her. Elizabeth hugged her too. Cinder sneezed glitter smoke on all three of them. On the flight home, Dad said, "What a peaceful vacation."

Page 148

Mom looked at the girls. The girls looked at Max. Max looked at the luggage trunk, which was humming. "Very peaceful," Elizabeth said. Back at the castle, they returned Cinder to the cave. The invisible wall opened for him as if it had missed him. He curled into the silver moss, blue harness glowing faintly. Scarlet sat beside him. "We are still your family."

Page 149

Elizabeth touched the sea-glass necklace. "And now we know your family was bigger than we thought." Max installed new sensor blockers. Leilani wrote letters. Mrs. Rosie sent a field trip permission slip that looked suspiciously like another clue. In the Ladybug Room, Elizabeth opened the notebook to a fresh page. Case number three: The Tides Remember..

Page 150

Scarlet leaned over her shoulder. "That sounds like a sequel." Elizabeth smiled. Outside, the fixed vase caught the sunlight. Gold veins shimmered like roads leading everywhere. And deep in the cave behind the waterfall, Cinder dreamed of flying..